



City of Cambridge

COF 2026-109
FIRST IN COUNCIL
August 19, 2026

WHEREAS:

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RESOLVED:

RESOLVED:

A true copy;

ATTEST:-

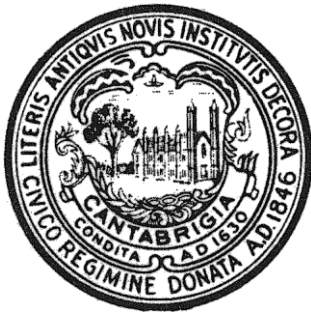
A handwritten signature in cursive script, reading "Paula M. Crane".

Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk



City of Cambridge

A communication was received from Jeff Roberts, Director of Zoning and Development, transmitting the Planning Board Report on the Short-Term Rentals Zoning Petition.



CITY OF CAMBRIDGE, MASSACHUSETTS

PLANNING BOARD

CITY HALL ANNEX, 344 BROADWAY, CAMBRIDGE, MA 02139

Date: August 13, 2026

Subject: Short-Term Rentals Zoning Petition

Recommendation: The Planning Board recommends adoption, with comments.

To the Honorable, the City Council,

On August 4, 2026, the Planning Board (the “Board”) held a public hearing to discuss a Zoning Petition by the City Council to amend the Cambridge Zoning Ordinance in Section 4.60, which regulates short-term rentals of residential dwelling units (the “Petition”). The Petition would add definitions, add and revise conditions, add registration requirements with required documentation, limit short-term rentals to 90 days per calendar year, require compliance with all building, zoning, sanitary, or fire codes or related regulation, add enforcement mechanisms for violation of the ordinance, authorize ISD to promulgate regulations to carry out and enforce the ordinance and its amendments, and revise other parts of the ordinance for internal consistency.

The Board heard a presentation from representatives of the Cambridge Inspectional Services Department (“ISD”) and Law Department, who prepared the Petition, and received oral and written comments from members of the public. After discussion with City staff and deliberating on the Petition, the Planning Board voted to send a positive recommendation to the City Council.

Board members supported the efforts on the part of ISD and the Law Department to ensure that the City has effective tools to enforce requirements for short-term rentals. The number of unregistered short-term rentals is a primary concern, and the main benefit of this Petition is to better enable the City to bring those properties into compliance. The impact of non-compliant short-term rentals that reduce the availability of housing in Cambridge is a major planning concern. However, Board members were also convinced by public testimony that the flexibility to operate short-term rentals plays an important role in helping many Cambridge residents remain in their homes. Short-term rentals also help fulfill important community needs that rely on accommodating visitors.

Board members only raised issues with two aspects of the Petition. Most of the public testimony was related to the proposed 90-day-per-year limit on operating a short-term rental and the impact it would have on existing, registered short-term rental operators. Board members did not fully understand the rationale for this limitation, and were

concerned that it created an onerous impact on registered short-term rentals that could detract from the primary goal of bringing unregistered short-term rentals into compliance.

The Board's understanding is that there may be a concern about "autonomous" short-term rentals being operated as year-round short-term rentals, in violation of their intent. Board members suggested that the issue could be better addressed by enforcing requirements to ensure that the unit is the operator's true primary residence. Further changes could be considered if there are significant problems with registered autonomous short-term rentals over time. If a limitation is imposed, Board members suggested that it should not apply to owner-occupied or owner-adjacent short-term rentals, and that more than 90 days should be permissible for autonomous short-term rentals.

The other concern raised by Board members was related to the amount of procedural detail that would be codified into the Zoning Ordinance if the Petition is adopted. This amount of detail could be a concern if ISD needs to adjust how the rules are applied over time, because any change would involve the lengthy process of amending the Zoning Ordinance. Board members encouraged considering whether some procedural details could be contained in a separate municipal ordinance, regulations, or administrative policies to allow for future flexibility. However, Board members were also deferential to the opinions of ISD and Law Department staff.

Board members also expressed appreciation for the quality of information presented, especially from the community survey. After implementing new requirements, ISD is encouraged to continue collecting data to monitor the effects of short-term rentals in Cambridge.

The Planning Board voted 7-0 in favor of transmitting the above report.

Respectfully submitted for the Planning Board,



Tom Sieniewicz, Chair.